

ANI

stered Uddhav's legitimacy? Observers unfailingly speak of popular sympathy for a rightful inheritor who had been wronged—that too of a party central to Maharashtrian identity politics for decades. The 2023 split in the NCP only appeared to sharpen that perception. And the Mahayuti seems to be aware that, most of all, it's on that turf of popular psychology that it has to wage its battle. At a Pune rally on a sweltering April afternoon, its leaders took comfort in numbers. On stage was that salad bowl leadership recent events had produced: Fadnavis, Ajit, former minister Harshvardhan Patil who had switched from the Congress to the BJP, and the NCP's Dattatray Bharane who had defeated Patil twice, in 2014 and 2019, from the Indapur assembly seat in Pune. Pointing to the multitude of leaders on the stage, Fadnavis thundered: "While it takes around seven to eight lakh votes to win... those on this stage have the ability to bring in 12 to 15 lakh votes."

WHAT IS BOLSTERING THE BJP'S CONFIDENCE IS THAT WHILE THERE MAY NOT BE A GAME-ALTERING MODI WAVE LIKE IN 2014-2019, THE OPPOSITION HAS YET TO THROW UP A FIGURE OF MATCHING STATURE

And yet, despite the brave words, those from the Mahayuti ranks admit two plus two is not always four in the byzantine world of politics. The splits in the two traditional parties are an emotive issue. The spectre of defections brings no moral sheen. After two years of NDA rule, there's also pent-up anti-incumbency—the government has kept the powder dry by routinely putting off elections to local bodies. Also, a quota demand-fuelled caste divide between the dominant Marathas and resurgent OBCs, with an attendant realignment of social forces. An increasingly bipolar polity leaves smaller players chafing, and leaders on the same side are often acting at cross-purposes. In sum, this is as multi-layered an election as can be imagined. And a tough one to call, a psephologist's nightmare—a mesh of micro-battles in 48 constituencies.

It's the sense that this is a case of stolen identity, not a victory through open competition, that has given the MVA its most potent plank—a strong regional narrative to beat back the Mahayuti. At Solapur, Uddhav was not mincing his words. "This is not your degree for it to be called *nakli*. This is the *asli* (real) Shiv Sena and you will know on June 4 how hard this Sena can hit," he warned.

MVA leaders invariably affirm the sympathy factor. "Two regional parties were split by the BJP to come to power...the people of Maharashtra are upset if their self-respect is hurt," says Pawar associate Pravin Gaikwad of the Maratha organisation Sambhaji Brigade. "In our family system, elders are respected. If the elderly are attacked, the people are hurt." Opposition leaders also lay it on thick when it comes to critiquing the BJP for using central investigation agencies like the Enforcement Directorate (ED) to get leaders like Ajit and Chavan on their side—buoyed by a conviction that this narrative has struck a chord with the people. Ajit's split from the NCP came just days after PM Modi charged that party with corruption at a public meeting in Madhya Pradesh. Likewise, Ashok Chavan's exit from the Congress in February came after a white paper on the Indian economy, released by the Centre, mentioned the alleged Adarsh Housing Society scam that cost him the CM's chair in 2010. Even a BJP leader from Mumbai worries the "washing machine" analogy may have caught on.

BJP leaders, however, are confident that any regional disenchantment would be obliterated by the narrative around Modi. Moreover, the unprecedented five-phase polling this time—as opposed to three in 2019—means the BJP will perhaps be the only party with the resources and the stamina to last the distance. A former BJP minister admits to an emotional leaning in favour of Uddhav and